

North African tempeh tagine

I call this my vegetarian goulash, though the sweet-spicy flavors are closer to those of the Mediterranean, as the title implies. I like to serve it with eggs or with rice or couscous and a salad. As with many stews, this one tastes especially good the next day—and believe it or not, even better the day after that. The spices have an almost **magical** quality to them as they combine in a mouthwatering crescendo. If you don't already, I recommend buying fresh bulk spices rather than using jarred ones that have been in your cabinet for many weeks or months. Fresh spices mean the difference between a decent dish and an outstanding dish.

2 medium carrots, peeled and roll-cut or sliced diagonally into ½-inch [1-cm] pieces

1 teaspoon fenugreek

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

½ teaspoon whole black peppercorns

½ teaspoon coriander seeds

½ teaspoon caraway seeds

½ teaspoon paprika

¼ teaspoon black mustard seeds

2 whole cloves

1 small onion, finely chopped

1 tablespoon olive oil

4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced

6 dates, pitted and coarsely chopped

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

⅔ cup vegetable stock [150ml]

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh, cut into ¾-inch [2-cm] cubes [250g]

2 tomatoes, seeded and coarsely chopped

Salt and hot sauce

1. **Preheat** the oven to 375°F [190°C]. Steam or boil the carrots until they are bright orange and just barely tender, 4 to 5 minutes. Set aside.
2. In a large dry skillet, **toast** the fenugreek, cumin, peppercorns, coriander, caraway, paprika, mustard seeds, and cloves over medium heat until they turn a shade or two darker and become aromatic, 2 to 3 minutes. Stir constantly to prevent burn-

ing. Transfer the spices to a small plate and let cool; then grind to a fine powder in a spice grinder or mini food processor.

3. In the same skillet, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until soft and lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes. Add the garlic and cook for another 2 to 3 minutes, until the garlic is softened. Add the spice mixture and mix well. Cook for another minute or so, until fragrant.
4. In a small bowl, **mash** the chopped dates with a fork. Mix in the tamarind paste and 2 tablespoons of the stock with the back of a spoon until well blended and smooth. Add the remaining vegetable stock to the skillet and bring to a boil. Stir in the date-tamarind combination and mix well. Add the tempeh, tomatoes, and steamed carrots. Season with salt and hot sauce to taste. If the stew seems somewhat dry, add additional vegetable stock or water to make sure the ingredients are just barely covered with liquid. Bring to a boil.
5. Transfer the entire stew to a covered baking dish or casserole. **Bake** for 20 to 30 minutes, until the dish is hot and bubbling and the potatoes are tender.

SERVES 4

note I recommend adding a dash of medium-hot hot sauce to this recipe, not because it's not spicy enough, but because a little extra kick seems to do it just right. Another idea you might find helpful is to double the spice mix and store it for use in this or other recipes you might make in the near future. Sealed well and kept out of direct light, the spice mix will stay fresh for about 3 to 4 weeks.